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ALPR cameras track Iowa drivers with few regulations, ACLU report finds

New study reveals 48 agencies use automated license plate recognition technology across Iowa

Automated license plate recognition cameras are tracking thousands of vehicles daily across Iowa with little state regulation.

By [Andrew Pfeifer](#)

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COUNCIL BLUFFS, Iowa. (WOWT)- [Automated license plate recognition cameras](#) are tracking thousands of vehicles daily across Iowa with little state regulation, according to a new report from the University of Iowa and the ACLU.

The technology has expanded rapidly across the state, with 48 agencies now using ALPR cameras, the ACLU of Iowa study shows. Council Bluffs has 37 cameras scattered throughout the city.

“Over the last couple of years they have just exploded in our state and nationally,” said Rita Bettis Austen, legal director for the ACLU of Iowa.

Privacy concerns grow as cameras multiply

The cameras are small enough that drivers likely don’t know they’re passing one, Bettis Austen said. They continuously record license plates of every passing vehicle, helping law enforcement build a database of vehicle information.

Some cities have up to 50 cameras each, the report found.

“This has all taken our already significant privacy civil right liberty concerns from the days back in 2014 and put them on steroids,” Bettis Austen said.

Council Bluffs resident Tonnya Fargnola said she finds the surveillance concerning.

“I think it’s kind of creepy... and I think the point of it was so they can stop and give red light tickets,” Fargnola said.

However, these are not red light cameras. They record continuously regardless of traffic violations.

Error rates raise safety concerns

“That does mean that you can be targeted by police as being on a hotlist, an error for example, and that has happened in the past,” she said.

Bettis Austen recalled incidents where cars were held at gunpoint due to ALPR errors.

“Unfortunately, we do know that ALPR’s have been abused by police,” she said.

Under Iowa law, no warrant is required for law enforcement to use the ALPR database.

Costly investment with limited oversight

Some cities have made significant financial investments in the technology. According to the report, Cedar Rapids has spent as much as \$240,000 per year in taxpayer money on the cameras.

“I don’t see the point of all the money and all the cameras spent on them if they aren’t getting the right information,” Fagnola said.

The growing use of ALPR cameras has caught the attention of Iowa legislators.

“This has gotten legislators attention on the right side of the issue. What we recommend right now is to press pause on these,” said Pete McRoberts, policy director for the ACLU of Iowa.

The ACLU’s primary recommendation to cities is to pause adding more cameras and explore alternatives that protect individual privacy.

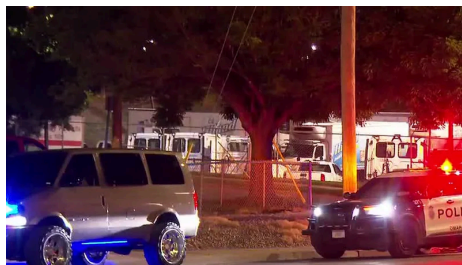
“So our recommendation to cities is number one just don’t do this and look at all your options to return to protecting individual privacy,” McRoberts said.

Until regulations are in place, the ACLU hopes to inform the public about the technology and advocate for a pause on additional camera installations.

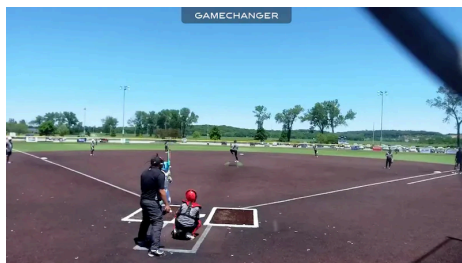
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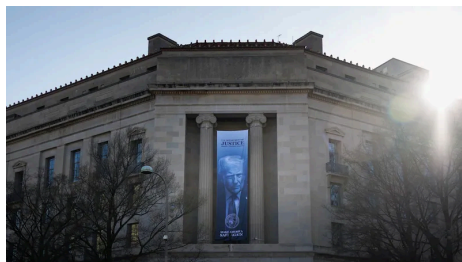
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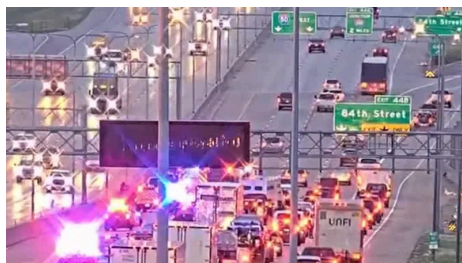
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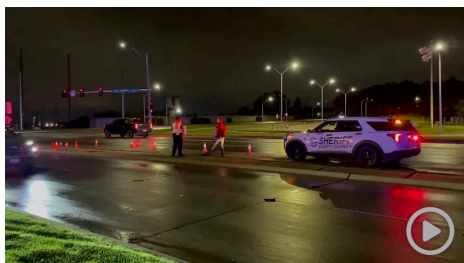
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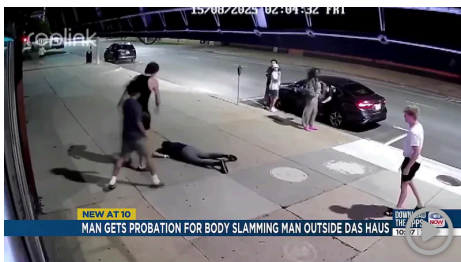
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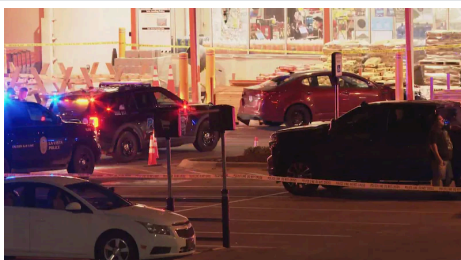
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